Report to Congress on Unexploded Ordnance Clearance in Ukraine

Pursuant to Section 7019(e) of the Department of State, Foreign Operations, and Related Programs Appropriations Act, 2024 (Div. F, P.L. 118-47), as carried forward by the Full-Year Continuing Appropriations Act, 2025 (Div. A, P.L. 119-4), and Senate Report 118-71

The Russia/Ukraine war has littered massive swaths of Ukraine with landmines, unexploded ordnance (UXO), and improvised explosive devices on a scale not seen since World War II. International experts estimate that Russia has laid more than two million persistent landmines across Ukraine. Russian munitions have dud rates between 10 and 30 percent, resulting in massive amounts of UXO, which, coupled with persistent landmines, continue to block access to farmland, impede reconstruction efforts, prevent displaced communities from returning to their homes, and kill and maim Ukrainian civilians. The Government of Ukraine (GoU) originally estimated that 174,000 square kilometers – approximately one-third of Ukraine's territory – may be contaminated by explosive hazards. In September 2024, the GoU updated its estimate to 139,000 square kilometers due to progress in surveying land, finding no evidence of contamination in some areas and returning some land to productive use. As

of May 2025, Ukraine has recorded more than 4,500 confirmed or suspected hazardous areas within that territory and aims to complete non-technical survey of accessible areas by 2026.

A report from the Tony Blair Institute for Global Change released in September 2024, in conjunction with Ukraine's Ministry of Economy, estimates that landmines and unexploded ordnance impact Ukraine's GDP by $11.2 billion annually, compared to 2021, by rendering vast tracts of Ukraine off-limits to productive economic activity. Given the major role of agricultural exports in Ukraine's GDP, these hazards place an outsized impact on Ukraine's agricultural sector. According to open data sources, including official Ukrainian statistics, American businesses have lost more than $4.5 billion because of reduced sales of agricultural equipment and supplies and damaged infrastructure resulting in a decreased capacity to trade Ukrainian food on international markets. Several U.S. agribusinesses have reported their operations are limited by landmine contamination in Ukraine, including ADM, Cargill, and Corteva – all of which have donated funding to support demining efforts.

Since demining is a critical enabler of humanitarian aid, reconstruction and recovery efforts, returning areas contaminated with explosive hazards to productive use is a top priority for the GoU. The GoU has dedicated substantial national resources to clear explosive remnants of war, with the State Special Transport Service (SSTS), State Emergency Services (SESU), and National Police (NPU) jointly deploying more than 5,400 deminers. These GoU efforts, however, are hampered by a lack of basic equipment, manpower shortages, and training gaps.

On June 28, 2024, the GoU approved its National Mine Action Strategy for the period 2024 to 2033. The strategy codifies the high priority placed by Ukraine on demining efforts and outlines key actions to accelerate the demining process and return 80 percent of potentially contaminated land to productive use by 2033. Even with the strategic and effective use of Ukraine's resources, Ukrainians will likely live with explosive hazard contamination for decades.

The United States is the largest single donor of funding for humanitarian demining in Ukraine, alongside 48 other donors. The Department is leading the USG's response. The Department's programs are designed to bolster the GoU's own capacity to clear landmines and UXO in the decades ahead, while simultaneously augmenting GoU capabilities with demining teams fielded by nongovernmental organizations. The Department has trained more than 2,170 Ukrainian government deminers to date in an effort to build longer-term sustainability. U.S. assistance is a targeted investment with European and other donors providing three dollars for every dollar provided by the United States.

The Department of State's Office of Weapons Removal and Abatement (WRA) coordinated demining activities with other USG agencies and donors. For example, PM/WRA participated in USAID's AGRI-Ukraine initiative to strengthen the linkages between demining and agricultural recovery in Ukraine, and to share its expertise on demining with AGRI-Ukraine partners. Bolstering Ukraine's economy and fostering sustainable recovery, the initiative targeted urgent agricultural value chain development while advancing U.S. prosperity by increasing the sales of U.S. firms that operate

on the Ukrainian market. WRA's participation in the initiative was intended to raise awareness of demining efforts, encourage more private sector contributions for demining, and connect private sector donors with the appropriate Ukrainian authorities and data sources to ensure that agricultural assistance activities accounted for, and were sequenced properly with, demining operations.

Ukraine's First Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Economy, Yulia Svyrydenko, is currently responsible for strengthening Ukraine's demining policy, improving bureaucratic procedures, and coordinating with Ukrainian agencies and international partners to implement the strategy. Svyrydenko co-chairs the Sectoral Working Group (SWG) on Humanitarian Demining alongside the UN Resident Coordinator and the Ambassador of Japan. The SWG meets on a quarterly basis to coordinate demining priorities and has 69 representatives, encompassing 48 partner countries and organizations. The U.S. Embassy in Kyiv attends the SWG meetings in Kyiv, and WRA joins virtually.

Ukraine complements coordination in Kyiv with an annual, high-level conference focused on humanitarian demining. Croatia and Ukraine co-hosted the first conference in Zagreb in October 2023, and Switzerland and Ukraine held the second conference in Lausanne in October 2024. Leadership from the Bureau of Political-Military Affairs participated in both. Donors have also participated in expert-level coordination workshops annually since 2022 and provide information on demining support to the Ukraine Donor Platform. The United States also participates as an observer to the Lithuania and Iceland-led Demining Coalition under the Ukraine

Defense Contact Group (UDCG). Finally, WRA organizes quarterly interagency coordination calls for all U.S. Government agencies involved with demining and explosive ordnance disposal assistance for Ukraine.

While these coordination mechanisms play a helpful role in communicating priorities and avoiding duplication, the Department's policy is to encourage Ukraine to take responsibility for coordinating demining operations and follow-on rehabilitation and reconstruction assistance, as this provides a longer-term and more sustainable solution. The Ministry of Economy, acting as a member of Ukraine's interministerial National Mine Action Authority, has taken on this responsibility with enthusiasm. For example, in addition to leading the development of the strategy, the Ministry is designing a prioritization system for demining tasks that is powered by artificial intelligence (AI). The system will integrate existing government databases and other sources to determine which minefields present the most risk to civilians and have the most economic potential. The Ministry intends for the system to include, among other data, satellite imagery, farm plots and different soil types, critical infrastructure, population centers, returns of refugees and internally displaced persons, and distance from schools and hospitals. If the system is successfully developed and implemented, it has the potential to transform Ukraine's current tasking process for demining operations and systematically select sites of critical importance for rehabilitation and reconstruction activities.

Ukraine currently has 49 international donor countries (including the United States) and organizations that have pledged approximately $1.07 billion for humanitarian demining. With more than 4,500 hazardous areas that require

clearance, 101 demining operators, with additional organizations undergoing the certification process, and thousands of deminers, Ukraine has a massive challenge to effective coordination. However, a series of layered coordination platforms, the recently approved national strategy, and the Ministry of Economy's leadership have helped deconflict efforts and strengthen Ukraine's ability to effectively link demining with broader recovery efforts.